

After the Story: Open When You Need It

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

A companion study to *Water Gap Before Dawn*

Back to the Water Gap Fire

Pull a scrap of dry pine toward the ring before the Gap damp gets into it. We're going back to the Delaware Water Gap on the Pennsylvania side of Mount Minsi, where white blazes climb switchbacks above River Road, and Council Rock and Lookout Rock open on the Delaware and Tammany. Wet boots. Quartz gravel. A sealed envelope riding a jacket pocket like a small brick.

Micah Orth is twenty-three when he tells it, but the morning that matters he was nineteen running those switchbacks with Devon three steps behind him and a man named Kerr coming up the grade in a gas-station coat. Kerr used to pump gas by the interstate exit. What followed them wore Kerr's boots and hit the gravel wrong. River silt and burned copper rode the air. They found Kerr by empty pumps, ran for the trailhead by Lake Lenape, and went up because Kerr stood between them and the lot.

Three nights earlier, Grandma Ruth had put a thick envelope in Micah's hand under a Stroudsburg kitchen light. Packing tape sealed the flap twice. Block print: MICAH. OPEN WHEN YOU NEED IT. NOT BEFORE. A word that works, she said. Armor speech. Keep it shut until your hands are out of other tools. On Lookout Rock Micah tore the tape. Inside sat a notebook scrap with one Name: JESUS. Under that, four short commands: Armor on, lance out, speak and stand. Kerr backhanded Devon onto the stone. Micah spoke the Name, then the rest the way you speak a clear order to a stuck bolt, and pressed the scrap to his chest. Kerr stopped as if he had hit a wire and went downhill toward River Road.

Devon granted the stop on the rock. He refused the metaphysics before breakfast. Four years later he still argues that prayer is a noise brave people make when the body runs out of options. He will grant the stop. He will not grant a Person on the other end of the block print.

Tonight we sit with that Water Gap fire and ask what a sealed scrap teaches when the tape finally tears, and what Rick Renner confirms when he names prayer a lance you hurl, not a charm you wear for show.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read Ephesians 6:10-18, where believers are told to put on the whole armor of God and to pray at all times in the Spirit with all prayer and petition. On Lookout Rock Micah did not preach at Kerr. He opened a sealed work order and spoke plain. What does armor without a lance of prayer leave unfinished when boots hit gravel wrong behind you?
2. Read John 14:13-14 and Acts 4:12, where asking in Jesus' name and the Name by which we must be saved sit in the same household of claims. Grandma Ruth wrote one Name large and a four-command line under it. What changes when the Name is treated as a work order your mouth can carry, not as a lucky scrap you keep sealed for luck?
3. Read 2 Corinthians 10:3-4 and 1 John 4:1-3, where the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power, and where we are told to test the spirits. Devon saw Kerr stop and still walked home unconverted. What do your own hands do with a sealed word and with testing when a friend will grant the stop and still call prayer noise?

The Teaching: Open When You Need It

Start where Micah started. Not with a podium. With wet boots on Minsi switchbacks, a sealed envelope taped shut, a notebook scrap with a Name and a work order, overlook stone underfoot, and a man in a gas-station coat whose gait no longer matched the pumps.

Kerr is scene pressure: once human, changed at the thinning veil, hungry for the sealed word. We build tonight's fire on what Micah's mouth and hands did when the tape tore, and on what Devon refused to pretend after the boots faded downhill.

Rick Renner opens the same kit in *Spiritual Weapons To Defeat the Enemy*. He walks the pieces believers still carry: loinbelt of truth, breastplate of righteousness, shoes of peace, shield of faith, helmet of salvation, sword of the Spirit, and the lance of prayer and supplication. Then he says those pieces "are still vital, effective, and powerful weapons for the Body of Christ today" (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, opening). The same set is still on the bench for us.

Hold the lance next to Grandma Ruth's block print.

Renner will not let prayer sit as a soft add-on at the end of a list. "I call this last weapon 'the lance of prayer and supplication.'" (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). Then the work of the tool:

"When you wield 'the lance of prayer and supplication,' this powerful prayer tool is thrust forward into the spirit realm against the malevolent works of the adversary." (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). That is not a campus speech. That is a thrust. Micah tore tape, spoke the Name, spoke the work order, and pressed paper to his chest. Armor on, lance out. Amen. Kerr's burned-copper smell thinned. Hands and mouth finished what the sealed flap had been waiting for.

Renner presses the throw, not the display case. "By forcibly hurling this divine instrument into the face of the enemy, you exercise the power God has given you to stop major obstacles from developing in your personal life." (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). Grandma Ruth called it armor speech. Pastor Mel had talked once about prayer as a tool you pick up when the dark presses, the same way you pick up a wrench. On Lookout Rock the dark pressed with a body and a wrong gait. He did not wave the scrap like a charm. He opened it when he needed it, and he hurled what was written the way Renner says a lance is hurled: forward, aimed, meant to land.

Now the sealed word, because the envelope was half the lesson.

OPEN WHEN YOU NEED IT. NOT BEFORE. That instruction is tool discipline, not magic theater. A wrench left sealed until the bolt sticks is still a wrench. Renner keeps prayer inside the armor set: "Prayer is a part of our spiritual equipment." (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). Equipment you leave racked while you argue about metaphysics does not help when the veil thins before dawn. Micah kept the flap shut through Council Rock and the talus chute. His hands decided they were out of other tools on Lookout Rock. That is when the Name and the four commands became a work order instead of a pocket brick.

Walk the morning the way the tools walked it.

First the envelope. Thick paper. Double tape. A hard gate: not before. Grandma Ruth handed him a sealed reminder small enough to ride a jacket through wet laurel. Renner's lance belongs in the same sentence as that seal: prayer ready to thrust when the need arrives, not performed early to prove you own the paper.

Second the scrap. One Name. Four commands. Armor on, lance out, speak and stand. Renner notes that "there are many forms of prayer available for us to use in our fight of faith" (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). Micah's form that morning was short because the chase was short. Scripture stands behind the paraphrase without a translation quote in our mouths: put on the

whole armor, and pray at all times in the Spirit (Ephesians 6:10-18). Ask in the Name (John 14:13-14). There is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved (Acts 4:12). Grandma Ruth said it clean: Armor is for wearing. A lance is for throwing. Paper is only the reminder. The Name does the work.

Third the stand on the stone. Micah pressed the scrap to his chest. Kerr could not cross while the word was held. That line is the story's finish, not a spell recipe. Test the spirits (1 John 4:1-3). Keep the scrap as equipment, not as a talisman apart from the Person named on it. The weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh (2 Corinthians 10:3-4). Renner will not soften the cost of leaving the lance on the rack: "we simply cannot maintain a victorious position apart from a life of prayer" (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). Then the hard edge: "without this vital spiritual weapon, we can be sure of absolute and total defeat!" (Renner, *Spiritual Weapons*, ch. 1). On Minsi, defeat looked like a changed man reaching for a sealed word while two kids still argued about opening it. The flap gave. The Name went out. Kerr went downhill.

Devon stays honest on this page. He saw the stop. He still calls prayer noise. We do not baptize his grant of the stop into a conversion he has not made. Renner's lance does not require you to fake a friend's faith. Micah keeps the scrap in a sandwich bag in a glove box now. He does not open it for show. He does not preach it at Devon. When he needs it, his hands know the fold.

Scripture keeps the same pressure. Whole armor. Prayer in the Spirit. The Name. Weapons with divine power. Test the spirits. Ruth stayed plain. Devon stayed plain. The stop stayed a stop.

The veil along the Water Gap did not get a tidy map that morning. Devon granted the stop and not the metaphysics. Micah and Ruth did not close his file. We settle the sealed word. Open when you need it. Speak the Name. Hurl the lance. Put the reminder back in the bag before you drive toward Stroudsburg with wet boots on the pedals.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about the Devon in your crew, or the Devon in your own chest. The friend who will grant a stop when boots fade downhill, and who will refuse to let anyone baptize the scrap and call him converted. Say out loud where you have been trying to preach a sealed envelope into a testimony. Micah and Ruth left Devon honest. Renner's lance does not require you to fake a conversion that has not happened.

Talk about Ruth's tools. She sealed a Name and a work order and told Micah to wait until his hands were out of other tools. Where do you still tear tape early to prove you own the paper? Where do you still reach for a lecture when a short lance would do more work? Where do you need to quit being somebody else's Holy Spirit and simply speak the Name while your boots stay on the stone?

Talk about armor that includes prayer. Renner will not let you wear every piece except the lance and still call yourself ready. What piece have you been leaving sealed in a jacket because it looks less like equipment and more like words? Put the lance back in your hand this week the way Micah did: opened at need, named, aimed, finished with Amen while the work continues. Treat the scrap as a prayer tool. Do not treat it as a charm.

Try this, this week. Read Ephesians 6:10-18, John 14:13-14, Acts 4:12, 2 Corinthians 10:3-4, and 1 John 4:1-3 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. Write a short margin: OPEN WHEN YOU NEED IT. ARMOR ON. LANCE OUT. Then write SEALED TOOL on one side of a scrap and SHOW CHARM on the other. Ask which side your mouth has been living on when the dark presses and a friend will grant a stop but will not kneel. If you have been baptizing cracked lenses, set the sandwich bag back in the glove box in prayer and tell the truth about Devon's daylight. Learn a plain paraphrase you can say on overlook stone: put on the whole armor, and pray in the Spirit. Put another piece of pine on. Keep the fire high enough to show you the Gap and the road both. And when a friend stays Devon, leave the granted stop where the fire can see it, refuse the fake baptism, and thank God the Name still works when the tape finally tears.

Works Cited

Renner, Rick. *Spiritual Weapons To Defeat the Enemy: Overcoming the Wiles, Devices, and Deception of the Devil*. Tulsa: Teach All Nations, 2012. (Note New Edition 2012; ©1993 Rick Renner Ministries.)